

Yun Gee: The Blank in the History of Art in America

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“Art is a wound turned into light.” As a friend of Yun Gee, the French painter, Georges Braque, said this sentence probably not for this Chinese-American artist yet it concludes Yun Gee’s life and artistic career. As one of famous Chinese American artists of his time, Yun Gee had complicated personal experience that is strong associated with his creations. This paper goes through Yun Gee’s three major resident cities: San Francisco, Paris, and New York. From the three selected paintings, which reveal the artist’s personal experience in these periods, one would able to see the artist’s secret expressions belong to his times.

San Francisco: *Where Is My Mother*

In the *Introduction of Yun Gee: Poetry, Writings, Art, Memories*, Anthony Lee, the author, described the artist’s early year experience. Yun Gee was born in a southern province of China. Since childhood, the artist had influenced by Sun Yat-sen and joined in Kuomintang, Sun’s nationalist party, in his teenage. Later, Yun Gee migrated to the United States from China to join his father at the age of fifteen. Having left home at such a young age, the young artist faced not only emotional loneliness but also alienation as a minority in society. Yun Gee arrived in America during the peak of the exclusionary laws. It was a period that Chinese immigrants could only active in certain area, Chinatown, and government also passed pressure against them, by publishing restrictions. Under such circumstance, Yun Gee still chose to step into the world of art. Enrolling as a student in the California School of Fine Art, Yun Gee opened his first exhibit in 1926. In the same year, he founded Chinese Revolutionary Artists’ Club, an artistic collective club. The word “revolutionary” obtains double meaning for the artist: his modernist painting style as well as the political situation as a Chinese immigrant.

Creating in the same year of the establishment of his artistic club, *Where Is My Mother* vividly depicts his early artistic achievements as well as his internal spiritual world. The painting catches the audience's attention with three headshots with giant tears on their faces in the foreground. The figure on the right is recognized as the painter himself. Yun Gee depicts his face with the expression of a young but sophisticated man. His eyes indicate perplexity and sorrow with direct contact with viewers. The background is composed using colorful geometric forms. Steamboats and factories faintly appear between polychrome semicircles and triangles. A Chinese worker, symbolized by his bamboo hat, stands alone in the center of the painting among other chaotic figures in the background. It seems that the only thing the worker can rely on in the landscape behind him is a tree without leaves. The sharp colors, contrasts and composition, influenced by his teacher Otis Oldfield, depicts the artist's feeling of loss. On a personal level, he missed his mother, who had to remain in China because of the restrictions against immigrants. In a broader sense, this painting generalizes the circumstances of many Asian Americans, who are still considered foreigners and excluded from the mainstream United States. Yun Gee's paintings always embodied his sensitive emotional nature, and there is hardly any sense of playfulness in his later works given his social background. This early work reveals Yun Gee's characteristic personal style: strong emotions through a playful use of color.

Paris: *My First Impression of Paris*

There are several guesses of Yun Gee's leave of San Francisco: that the artist was influenced by his teacher, Otis Oldfield, who had experience in Paris and that his patrons, the Prince and Princess Achille Murate, pushed him to Paris. More importantly, the anti-

Chinese sentiment might be the major causation. Due to the Immigration Act published in 1924, Chinese Americans had been limited their income sources and active areas. This act had significant impact to this young Chinese-American artist, so much so that he still hold repel feeling against the city of San Francisco even in later of his life¹. At this period of his life, Yun Gee was eager to prove his potential in a more tolerant environment, to somewhere he could be considered only by his artwork not his oriental background. Paris became his ideal choice.

Yun Gee created *My First Impression of Paris* in the year of 1926. As a San Francisco Chinatown inhabitant, this humble young man presented his astonishment and ecstasy to the metropolitan city. The painting depicts Paris under moonlight. Next to the bright yellow moon, Eiffel Tower served as the landmark of Paris, is placed as apart of the background. In the middleground, buildings are twisted in a Salon Cubist style. Even though the city is in its late night, the boulevard was still occupied by pedestrians. Ladies are shown in the latest fashion, while men are depicted with grace and dignity. The French lovers are kissing in the middle of the street, as if there were no one present. In the foreground is composed by a light from a bar or café shop that gives audiences sense of space extension. All these flourishing nightlife were unachievable for Yun Gee when he was in Chinatown in San Francisco. The anti-gravity twisting architectures and the wine glass obscurely suggest the artist may be in intoxication during the creation. It is not hard to tell a positive emotion that is very unlike his previous art works in San Francisco.

New York: *Wheels: Industrial New York*

¹ Anthony W. Lee, p 12

“Painting from nature is not copying the object; it is realizing one’s sensations.” Paul Cézanne’s conclusion to his own experience on painting also suits in Yun Gee’s experience. The start of World War Two pushed Yun Gee from Paris back to America. Instead of going back to San Francisco, Yun Gee chose New York, a popular place known for its inclusiveness, to continue his creation. *Wheels: Industrial New York* was created when the artist newly arrived in this city during the Great Depression.

The whole painting presents flourishing chaos but irony discrimination. Yun Gee takes Brooklyn Bridge, a new icon of New York City, as a subject, and vividly depicts a sense of devastation, which stealthily grows with the prosperity of the City. The landmarks and skyscrapers composed the background of the painting. Yun Gee depicts the background in such an attention that an audience can easily identify each building if he or she is familiar with New York. The composition of the Sun and an aircraft in the same height presents the achievement in technology straightway. Brooklyn Bridge almost occupies the entire left side of canvas and extends into the background. Yun Gee puts his focus on the activities happening under the bridge. A group of men are holding brassies on horses. In mid 1900s, polo is considered as typical American middle-class leisure. However, a woman and her child are excluded from this group activity. The color combination further pushes the irony in this painting, while expresses a clue of the artist’s mental issue. Bright colors, which Yun Gee very possibly takes from Cezanne’s work in his time in Paris, occupy the majority of space. From the background to the circling crowded, the painting presents prosperity and flourishing its warn-toned. The choice of bright color strongly contrast the social background at that time, the Great Depression. The irony use of color pushes further when Yun Gee toughly adds linear chimneys in

black that shape like strokes in Chinese calligraphy in ink. A man outlined by black color seems to falling from the roof of a building. This man is the only figure not depicted in Cezanne's colorful way, and more likely in *paimiao*, a traditional Chinese style of drawing by only outline the figure. Some scholars argue that Yun Gee identifies himself as this black outlined figure. If so, this might be the earliest sign of his depression.



Detail, Yun Gee, *Wheels: Industrial New York*, Oil on Canvas, 1932

Conclusion

Creativity takes courage. As a pioneer in the art field, Yun Gee persevered in his artistic career under great pressure. In early years, the artist had been suffered in poverty, while he was struggling with mental issues in later years of his life. The constant political inferior limited Yun Gee's artistic achievement. However, this disadvantage also pushed

him to challenge himself, in order to receive the same recognition as other non Asian American artists from the same period.

Yun Gee's art works obtains limited appreciation. One important reason that Yun Gee has not been accepted is that Asian Americans were always a minority in the period when he was active. Another law was passed against Asian Americans after the end of the exclusion era. In 1941, Japan attacked Pearl Harbor. The government forced Japanese Americans to relocate to internment camps, and conflicts against Asian Americans intensified. Society accepted few artists with an Asian background, and Yun Gee was not among them. Further, mainstream critics and art dealers did not appreciate Yun Gee's style. His combination of Western Cubism with Oriental elements did not fit the tenor of his time. Yun Gee failed to catch the art circle's attention but did evoke many Asian immigrants' feelings of homesickness and alienation.

Yun Gee is a talented artist but has been forgotten by the world. Even though he spent his first fifteen years in China, mainland Chinese art history seldom mentions him. Meanwhile, Western art critics have only recently started to notice his genius. His artworks vividly depict his inner conflicts as an outsider who is all alone in a foreign land.

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